



**MASTERMIND
INDIA**

Spirit of India Special

THE HANDYREADER

It's an innovation set to transform the way Indians read. Vishal Mehta, 33, a technocrat from Ahmedabad is creating waves with his pocket-sized e-book reader that is not only giving Amazon's Kindle a run for its money by keeping its price low, but is also catering to the huge appetite of Indians who read regional languages. Named Infibeam Pi, the product supports 10 Indian languages as well as English, and retains all the major features of Kindle like the E-Ink screen. Priced

at Rs 9,999 as against Rs 18,000 for Kindle, its copyright architecture is more open.

With an ambition of starting his own retail portal in India, Mehta left a swanky lifestyle in US with his wife Nirali for Ahmedabad in 2008. Thus was born Infibeam.com, an online retail portal that sells everything from flowers to jewellery to books. There are around two lakh e-books available on the portal whose copyrights have expired, for instance *The Adventures of Sherlock Holmes* whose

**THE INDIGENOUS
VERSION OF KINDLE
HELPS DOWNLOADING
BOOKS AT A LOW COST
AND THOSE WITH
EXPIRED COPYRIGHTS.**

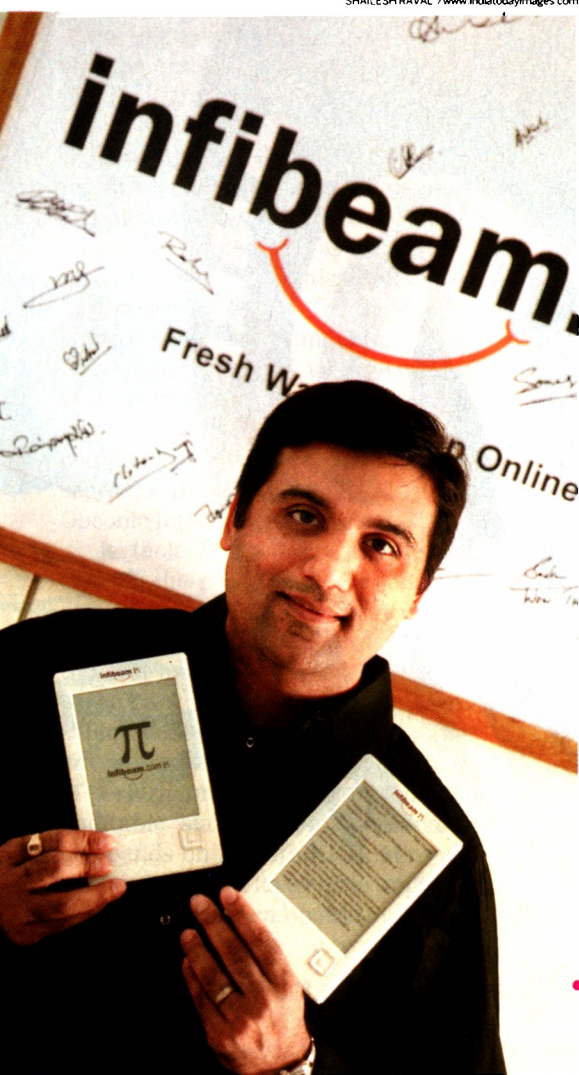
rights have expired, but the book still costs Rs 500. These can be downloaded from the Internet and read on Pi for free. Says Mehta, a technocrat who studied at the Sloan University in the Massachusetts Institute of Technology and worked with Amazon before returning to Ahmedabad, "My aim is make Pi a full-fledged infrastructure service provider by turning it into an online platform for publishing houses and bookstores."

The 7 X 5 inch Pi that weighs 180 gm is a reader-friendly device. With a micro USB port to connect to a PC, users will need to create an account with Infibeam.com, register the device and then download the e-books. The search option has been so designed that it makes the task effortless. Flipping from one page to another or going to an entirely different chapter of a book has also been made equally easy. Pi has a capacity of 512 MB which can store about 500 books.

Viewed as a moving infrastructure device, Pi is set for greater heights as Mehta packs the product with a wireless 3G connection and applications like email and financial services. That's where Mehta scores, and seems will continue to: his keep-at-it drive to innovate won't be found wanting in the e-sweepstakes just because he has one good product under his belt.

by Uday Mahurkar

SHAILESH RAVAL / www.indiatodayimages.com



**Vishal
MEHTA, 33**

INNOVATION

Infibeam Pi

COST

Rs 9,999

WHAT IT DOES

**A pocket-sized
e-reader that
downloads books
in regional
languages**

• MEHTA WITH THE
INFIBEAM PI